



OFF-SIDE

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MANU BHAKER AND THE GRACE OF TRUE CHAMPIONS

In a world full of the self-deluded and petulant, it was refreshing to witness the **charm of a young champion** at the recently concluded Sportstar Aces Awards.

Success is a funny thing. One day, you're just another person wandering around, and the next, people start acting as if you've arrived straight from Mount Olympus. It's surreal how quickly ordinary life can turn into a quasi-religious spectacle.

The problem with pedestals is that they tend to come with a free side of delusion — a little voice whispering: *Yes, you are different. Yes, you are special.* Athletes, artists, politicians — the ones who get all the applause — are especially susceptible. If enough people tell you you're divine, it must be tempting to start believing it.

The rest of us, tragically ordinary, watch from below, wondering at what point they lost touch with reality.

But there are those who manage to stay grounded, no matter their extraordinary achievements. They're the ones who can handle the spotlight without demanding an altar — always nice, always human. They are the real champions: those who never forget how to be a regular person, even when others insist on their divinity.

In a world full of the self-deluded and petulant, it was refreshing to witness the charm of a young champion at the recently concluded Sportstar Aces Awards. Manu Bhaker, 23, is not weighed down by the gravity

of a double Olympic medal.

When most of today's celebrities dodge anything that doesn't promise a big paycheck, Manu raced against the clock to attend the Sportstar Aces in Mumbai. She was competing at the Karni Singh Range in the national capital until 2 p.m. but braved a 40-minute drive to Delhi airport, a two-hour flight, and the famously sluggish Mumbai traffic — all for an awards night she could have easily skipped.

After the awards wrapped up, most people sprinted off in search of champagne — or something stronger — but Manu lingered. She took selfies with anyone who asked, chatted as if she had nowhere better to be, and generally made you feel like you mattered.

It's tempting to call people like that rare. We've seen it with Neeraj Chopra at the 2022 Sportstar Aces, and Leander Paes does it practically every day — each time, they make people feel special, even when they have nothing tangible to offer in return.

It's easy to admire the discipline of champions, but it's far rarer to see them remain so accessible. Manu seems to have mastered it with the same calm precision she applies to shooting, effortlessly dodging the gravitational pull of self-importance.

And that's a real star: someone who treats you as if you're as special as the medal around their neck.